Feedback on the military recruitment scheme from various stakeholders has suggested several changes. With the issue exacting a heavy electoral cost too, Modi 3.0 is considering how to make it better

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SETTING THE BAR HIGH
Applicants undergo a physical test at the Agniveer Army recruitment test at Danapur Regimental Centre, Patna, November 2023

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MOST AGREE THAT THE SCHEME COULD DO WITH RAISING THE TENURE OR THE PERCENTAGE OF AGNIVEERS TO BE RETAINED

that the scheme could lead to a lack of experienced personnel and grievously impact the long-term effectiveness of the armed forces. Some even expressed concern about the possible militarisation of civil society.

Though the government launched an outreach programme to clarify the benefits of Agnipath—assured financial packages, educational opportunities and priority in state and central government jobs for those completing their four-year tenure—it failed to douse the fire of discontent. There were calls to scrap the whole thing, and in the year leading to the 2024 Lok Sabha election, many Opposition political parties made it a significant election plank. Driven to the back foot, the government conceded an inch—in March, Union defence minister Rajnath Singh said that the government was "open to bringing any change in Agnipath if required".

With election results from some of the states that comprise the Indian military's main recruiting fields—namely, Haryana, Punjab, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh—not returning a favourable verdict to the BJP and its allies, the NDA 3.0 government is now cautiously revisiting the Agnipath scheme. With a strengthened opposition certain to raise the issue in the first session of the 18th Lok Sabha, NDA allies Janata Dal (United) and Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) have urged the government to review it. While many believe that the government is unlikely to go back to the previous recruitment process, many military planners maintain that Agnipath needs major changes to meet the requirements of both the youth and the three services.

Likewise, the new Narendra Modi government has now entrusted the Department of Military Affairs, under the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS), with the task of conducting a review of Agnipath. Opinions of all stakeholders, including recruiting directorates, regimental training centres, field units where they are posted as well as that of the Agniveers themselves are being sought. The Indian Army, which gets the major share of Agniveers, has made several recommendations for its improvement, while the Indian Air Force and the Navy are currently reviewing it. Two key recommendations are to bring parity in battle casualty and disability dues between Agniveers and regular soldiers and setting up an agency to help Agniveers find jobs after their four-year service. Other experts advise hiking the 25 per cent intake percentage and increasing the years of service from four. Several high-ranking military officers even want Agnipath to be regarded as a pilot project for two years to test its efficiency. They suggest using the first cohort of Agniveers as a test bed to thoroughly evaluate the scheme's effectiveness before making any substantial changes.

"If the Constitution of India has